

August 2026

Dear Charles Mark,

I've worked in and around Lafayette for a long time, and properties like 490 St. Marys Road genuinely stand out - a gated, creek-side estate on nearly 1.5 acres with no visible neighbors and a kitchen that earns its own reaction is not something you encounter every week in this market. When I saw the listing come off market without a sale, it caught my attention in a different way, and that's why I'm writing.

Thirty-one days on market isn't a disaster, but for a home with this much going for it - the setting, the craftsmanship, the privacy, the sheer scale of the lot - it signals that the listing strategy didn't fully close the distance between what the property actually offers and what buyers were able to feel from the outside. At \$891 per square foot, the number is supportable, but only if the marketing does the work of building that case for buyers before they make the drive. From what I can see, that case wasn't fully made.

I've put together a packet that walks through what I think happened, why the fundamentals here are still strong, and how I'd approach a relaunch differently. It's specific to this property, not a generic playbook.

If you're already working with a real estate professional toward a new listing, please feel free to disregard this entirely, no hard feelings. If you're not, I'd welcome a short conversation whenever the timing is right for you.

With respect,



Ben Olsen

REALTOR · BrightWork Realty Advocates
(925) 255-9727 · brightworkrealty.com
455 Moraga Road, Suite I · Moraga, CA 94556

The Path to Sold:

490 St Marys Rd

Lafayette, CA 94549

4.0 Beds · 3 Baths · 3,144 Sq Ft · Lafayette

The Blueprint for a Successful Sale

Prepared For: The Owners of 490 St Marys Rd

Presented By: Ben Olsen · BrightWork Realty Advocates

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A Gated Creek-Side Estate with Custom Craftsmanship - and a Listing That Didn't Show It

490 St. Marys Road has the kind of combination that serious Lafayette buyers actively search for and rarely find together: a nearly 1.5-acre gated lot with a seasonal creek running through it, a 3,144-square-foot home built with contractor-grade materials and artistic custom detail, a kitchen significant enough to generate its own reaction, and a setting private enough that no neighboring structures are visible from the property. The 3-car garage with wood doors, the dual-entry gated driveway, and the wildlife-corridor setting along Las Trampas Creek are genuine differentiators in a market where most premium inventory sits on conventional suburban lots. These are the features that justify a premium price point, and they are real.

The listing history tells a different story. At \$2,800,000 and \$891 per square foot, this home sits at the high end of the Lafayette premium tier, which is a defensible position given what the property offers. But 31 days on market without a sale, on a home this distinctive, suggests that buyers encountered the number before they fully understood what the number was buying them. The listing description gestured at the features - 'WOW kitchen,' 'postcard views,' 'artistic flair' - without giving buyers the visual depth and narrative specificity to feel confident at this price. The strategy described the home in outline. It never handed buyers the reasons to believe.

\$2,800,000

List Price

\$891/sqft

Price Per Sq. Ft.

None

HOA Fees

A relaunch for this property needs to accomplish one specific thing: close the gap between what buyers see on a screen and what they would feel walking this land. The setting, the privacy, the creek, the craftsmanship - none of that translates through flat photography and a paragraph with exclamation points. The right buyer for this home exists. Getting there requires media and a narrative built to match the property.

MARKET FORENSICS: WHY IT DIDN'T SELL

Every expired listing has a story. Here's what the listing history tells us about what held this one back, and what a different strategy would have done.

Friction #1: The Visual Story of This Setting Was Never Told

A gated 1.5-acre estate with a seasonal creek, no visible neighbors, and a dual-entry driveway is not something a standard front-elevation photo can explain. Buyers scrolling at \$2,800,000 need to feel the scale and privacy of this property before they will invest the time to schedule a showing. The listing description used words like 'paradise' and 'postcard view,' but the visual record never showed buyers what those phrases meant in practice. At this price point, buyers are comparing carefully, and a property that can't be understood from the screen gets passed over in favor of one that can. The setting here is the premium. It needed to be the centerpiece of the visual campaign, not background context.

* THE BRIGHTWORK DIFFERENCE

BrightWork's Sky Tour captures the lot position, creek corridor, gated entry, and surrounding privacy from the air in a way ground photography simply cannot, giving buyers the spatial context that justifies the price before they ever set foot on the property.

Friction #2: A Premium Price Point With No Supporting Narrative

At \$891 per square foot, this home sits at the top of the Lafayette premium tier, which the property can support. But buyers comparing options at this level are analytical. They want to understand specifically what they are getting at that number that they cannot find in a \$750-per-square-foot alternative. The listing offered impressions - 'finest materials,' 'expert workmanship,' 'masterpiece' - without translating those impressions into concrete, specific proof. A kitchen that earns a 'WOW' reaction needs more than the word 'WOW' in the description. The custom features, the material quality, the contractor-built details - all of it needed to be named and shown with enough precision that buyers could build their own case for the number. Without that, \$891 per square foot reads as an ask, not a conclusion.

* THE BRIGHTWORK DIFFERENCE

BrightWork's Zillow Showcase placement pairs premium portal visibility with a narrative built the way a great buyer's agent would describe the home - specific, grounded in features, and structured to give buyers the rationale to arrive at the price with confidence, not skepticism.

Friction #3: Out-of-Area Buyers Who Were Never Reached

A property priced at \$2,800,000 in Lafayette draws from a specific buyer profile: SF and East Bay professionals who are ready to trade urban density for land, privacy, and something they genuinely cannot find in the city. These buyers research extensively online before they will consider driving to Lamorinda, and they need to encounter this property while they are actively in that research phase. A standard MLS distribution waits for buyers to find the listing. It does not go find them. The buyers most likely to pay full price for a creek-side gated estate with this level of privacy were probably not browsing the MLS in May - they were browsing neighborhood lifestyle content and targeted searches well before that. The distribution strategy needed to be built for where those buyers actually spend their attention.

* THE BRIGHTWORK DIFFERENCE

BrightWork's geo-targeted digital campaigns place this property directly in front of SF and East Bay buyers who are actively researching Lamorinda, reaching them at the point of consideration - before they've found what they're looking for - rather than waiting for them to find the MLS.

POSITIONING ANALYSIS

Metric	490 St. Marys Rd	Lafayette Market Context
Price per Sq. Ft.	\$891/sqft	Premium tier: \$850–\$920/sqft
Lot / Setting	1.50 acres, gated, creek-front, no visible neighbors	Typical premium lots: 0.25–0.50 acres, conventional suburban setting
Architectural Character	Contractor-built custom home, 1980, artistic detail throughout	Standard builder inventory, limited custom features
Premium Features	High-spec kitchen, 3-car garage with wood doors, dual-entry gated driveway, Las Trampas Creek frontage	Standard floor plan, single-car or 2-car garage, no water feature
HOA	None	Varies; \$0–\$300/mo in comparable Lafayette neighborhoods

The verdict: At \$891/sqft versus a benchmark range of \$850-\$920/sqft, this home sits in the middle of that range. At \$891 per square foot, this home is positioned near the middle of the Lafayette premium tier - a placement the property's lot size, privacy, custom construction, and creek-front setting can genuinely support. The gap between what the numbers say and what the listing accomplished is not a pricing problem. It is a marketing problem. The assets that make this home worth the number were never shown with enough specificity or visual depth for buyers to arrive at the price with confidence.

THE RELAUNCH STRATEGY: 3 PILLARS

We don't re-list this home. We relaunch it with new media, a narrative that finally does it justice, and distribution designed for the buyer it deserves.

Pillar I - Showing the Land, Not Just the House

Most buyers for a property like this will decide whether to schedule a showing based on what they can feel from the digital experience. A 1.5-acre gated creek-front estate with this level of privacy requires media that communicates scale, setting, and character - not just rooms. BrightWork's Sky Tour and Matterport 3D walk-through together give buyers the spatial and architectural depth to understand exactly what they are considering, from anywhere, before they make the drive. More informed buyers produce fewer wasted showings and stronger, more confident offers.

Pillar II - Building the Case for \$891 Per Square Foot

At the top of the Lafayette premium tier, the marketing has to do specific work. Every custom feature - the kitchen, the garage, the materials, the setting - needs to be named, described with precision, and shown with photography that earns the number rather than just asserting it. BrightWork writes listing narratives the way a great buyer's agent describes a home to a serious client: specific, honest, and structured to give buyers a reason to believe before they schedule a showing. The goal is to make the price feel like a conclusion, not a demand.

Pillar III - Finding the Right Buyer, Not Waiting for Them

The buyer for a gated creek-side estate at \$2,800,000 is a specific person, and they are not sitting on the MLS waiting for a new listing to appear. They are researching Lamorinda neighborhoods, privacy, land, and quality construction across multiple platforms before they ever contact an agent. BrightWork's geo-targeted digital campaigns and off-market private buyer list at offmarket.brightworkrealty.com put this property in front of those buyers during their research phase - not after they've already made other decisions. That is how a property like this finds the right buyer, rather than hoping the right buyer happens to find it.

A DIFFERENT OPTION: THE QUIET LISTING

Sell Without the Disruption

A traditional listing puts a sign in your yard, opens your door to strangers every weekend, and puts your home's history on public record. For a home that already went through one listing cycle, there's a better starting point.

BrightWork maintains an active private buyer list through our off-market platform. These are Bay Area buyers who've opted in specifically to receive property alerts before anything hits Zillow. They're motivated, pre-qualified, and they believe an off-market home represents a real opportunity, which means they engage seriously.

- * **No public days on market.** The prior listing history stays private. A new buyer sees none of it.
- * **No sign, no open houses, no disruption.** The sale is a private conversation between a motivated buyer and a motivated seller.
- * **Option to go public anytime.** If the right off-market offer doesn't materialize in an agreed window, we transition directly into a full relaunch strategy with no time lost.

* HOW IT WORKS

We alert our private buyer list through offmarket.brightworkrealty.com - Bay Area buyers specifically seeking properties before they go public. If a serious match emerges within the agreed window, we negotiate and close privately. If not, we launch the full relaunch strategy immediately, with clean momentum and no days-on-market exposure.

TIMELINE: THE BRIGHTWORK SMART WAY

Phase 1 - Pre-Market Preparation (Weeks 1–2)

Staging, full media production, and a Coming Soon campaign - or a quiet listing launch to our private buyer network, depending on your preference.

Phase 2 - Strategic Launch (Week 3)

Thursday launch on Zillow Showcase with the full media package in premium placement. Targeted SF/Oakland digital ads go live the same day.

Phase 3 - Momentum Management (Weeks 4–5)

Active follow-up on every save, inquiry, and open house visitor. Final Offer gives serious buyers a transparent channel to submit competitive offers.

Phase 4 - The Close (Weeks 6–7)

We engineer competition, not just field offers. Our process keeps both sides of the transaction moving cleanly toward a close.

WHY BRIGHTWORK REALTY ADVOCATES

- * **Deep local roots:** 45+ years in Moraga, Lafayette, and Orinda. Ground-level knowledge of what buyers in each community are actually paying for.
- * **Premium marketing as a baseline:** Cinematic photography, floor plans, 3D tours, and Sky Tours on every listing. Not a luxury add-on.
- * **Portal dominance:** Zillow Showcase and homes.com premium placement. More views, enhanced listing pages, all leads to your team.
- * **Modern offer tools:** Final Offer gives buyers a transparent path to engage and gives you real-time demand data in one place.
- * **True advocacy:** We don't re-list homes. We forensically review what went wrong and rebuild the strategy from the ground up.

This home has real assets that the market never got to properly evaluate. That's a correctable problem. The window to correct it is still open.

Ready to talk? brightworkrealty.com · (925) 255-9727

Scan to see what a relaunch looks like for your home: relaunch.brightworkrealty.com

Important Notice

If you have entered into a listing agreement or active representation agreement with a licensed real estate agent in connection with this property, please disregard this mailing.

BrightWork Realty Advocates is a licensed real estate team operated by Ben Olsen, REALTOR, California DRE License #01409268. This communication is not intended to solicit properties currently listed for sale or under active representation.

The market analysis and strategic observations contained in this report are based on publicly available listing data and BrightWork's professional assessment of market conditions. They are not a formal appraisal and should not be relied upon as a certified valuation.

All property data referenced in this report was obtained from public records and MLS history. BrightWork Realty Advocates makes no warranty as to the accuracy of third-party data sources.

brightworkrealty.com · (925) 255-9727 · 455 Moraga Road, Suite I, Moraga, CA 94556



DIRECT
(925) 255-9727

EMAIL
ben@brightworkrealty.com

WEB
brightworkrealty.com

OFFICE
455 Moraga Road, Suite I
Moraga, CA 94556

THE BRIGHTWORK ADVANTAGE

- Buy Before You Sell
- BrightFlip Pre-Sale Improvements
- Final Offer Platform
- Zillow Showcase + homes.com Premium
- Off-Market Network
- Built to Close Clean

YOUR LISTING ADVISOR

Ben Olsen

Founding Partner | REALTOR · BrightWork Realty Advocates · DRE# 02014153

Ben founded BrightWork on a specific premise: the best outcomes are built before a home ever lists. With twenty years serving the East Bay's most competitive submarkets, he's developed a clear point of view on what separates a sale that closes well from one that doesn't, and the preparation, marketing, and negotiation strategy to act on it.

He entered the workforce at 14 in construction, a background that shapes how he thinks about pre-sale decisions, disclosure strategy, and what buyers actually scrutinize at inspection. That's a different lens than most agents carry into a listing consultation.

His approach to marketing is built on the same logic. Every campaign is designed for your home's specific buyer, not the average buyer. Portal strategy, campaign integration, and buyer targeting aren't add-ons at BrightWork. They're the baseline. Pre-sale prep, real fixes, and full disclosure before the home lists. The preparation is the negotiation.

20+

YEARS SERVING
LAMORINDA

\$1B+

PROPERTIES
SOLD

1,000+

BUYERS &
SELLERS

WHY HE SENT YOU THIS PACKET

When a listing expires, Ben reviews it. Not to pitch you, but because after enough of them, the pattern of what goes wrong becomes clear. If you received this analysis, he looked at your specific property and has a specific point of view about what happened. That's the conversation he's offering. No listing agreement on the table. Just a review. He'll also walk you through programs that turn seller constraints into options, and show you what a transaction designed to get everyone to the closing table feeling good actually looks like.

Why BrightWork Realty Advocates

Rooted in Lamorinda since 1977. BrightWork is built on the premise that the best outcomes start before a home ever lists. An orchestrated campaign designed for your home's buyer, not the average buyer. Programs that turn seller constraints into options. Transactions designed so everyone gets to the closing table feeling good.

That's The Smart Way to Real Estate.

EIGHT REASONS SMART SELLERS CHOOSE BRIGHTWORK

01 Superior Presentation

Professional photography, floor plans, 3D tours, and Sky Tours on every listing. Not the luxury package. The baseline.

02 Premium Portal Presence

Zillow Showcase and premium homes.com membership. Higher view counts, better placement, and buyer inquiries that route to your listing team.

03 Integrated Campaigns

Every sign, mailer, and open house connects to a digital system. Curious neighbors become trackable leads.

04 Modern Offer Management

Real-time portal data guides pricing decisions. Final Offer platform for properties with strong multi-offer potential.

05 Financial Tools & Capital Programs

Capital to fund pre-sale improvements with no out-of-pocket cost until close. Plus programs that remove the timing trap entirely.

06 Off-Market Strategy

A private list of serious Bay Area buyers. Test demand quietly or gain early access before properties hit MLS.

07 Advocacy for Unsold Homes

When a home hasn't sold, we don't re-list at a lower price. We conduct a forensic review and relaunch with a rebuilt strategy.

08 Built to Close Clean

Pre-sale prep, real fixes, and full disclosure to every buyer before the house lists. He structures listings to attract the best first offers from a position no one can argue with. The preparation is the negotiation.

BrightWork has served Lamorinda since 1977. Over \$1 billion in local real estate sold.

Ben Olsen | (925) 255-9727 | ben@brightworkrealty.com | brightworkrealty.com

Not Every Home Needs a Public Launch.

For sellers who need privacy, flexibility, or a different kind of timing — BrightWork has a smarter first step.

Most agents know one approach: list on the MLS, hit the portals, hold open houses. That works for many homes. For sellers who need privacy, flexibility, or more control over timing, BrightWork offers a structured, documented private path to the right buyer — built on relationships in Lamorinda that go back to 1977.

OFF MARKET SELLING HAS ITS BENEFITS

Your Home, Your Timing, No Pressure

No days-on-market counter. No public record. No nosy neighbors. Your home stays entirely private until you choose otherwise, and if you do go public later, you start fresh, with a clean slate and zero wasted days behind you.

Buyers Who Are Actually Ready

BrightWork maintains a curated list of serious, pre-qualified Bay Area buyers who have asked to be notified about Lamorinda properties. They are not browsing Zillow. Every showing is by appointment, with someone who qualifies and is genuinely interested.

Real Feedback Before You Commit

An off-market phase gives you genuine buyer response before you decide whether to close privately or step into a full MLS campaign. Either way, you move forward with real data and momentum, not day-one guesswork.

BrightWork's network of private buyers and collaborative realtor relationships has served Lamorinda since 1977.

Over \$1 billion in local real estate sold.

Deep relationships in Moraga, Lafayette, and Orinda.

WHO THE PRIVATE PATH SERVES

The Privacy-First Seller

No public listings, no open houses, and no days-on-market counter visible to buyers and agents, for whatever reason, professional or personal.

The Seller Still Preparing

Test genuine demand while staging or repairs are still underway, without burning days on market before you are ready.

The Strategically Timed Seller

Your next move depends on how this one closes. Control the sequence rather than react to a public countdown clock.

The Seller Testing the Waters

Get real buyer feedback before committing to a full public launch — or decide you do not need one at all.

Your home. Your timeline. Your terms.

Ready to find out whether the private path is the right first step?

Ben Olsen | (925) 255-9727

ben@brightworkrealty.com | brightworkrealty.com